

COMMODITY ANALYST

The Boost From the Hard Assets Rotation

- Following a strong and volatile start for commodities in 2026, we analyze the price impact of active investors positioning (because, historically, index investors have had little, if any, impact on prices). How would sustained investor diversification into hard assets in an uncertain world affect commodity prices?
- **Large Boosts.** Investor diversification flows can drive large short-run price boosts because commodity markets are small vs. equities and bonds. We see greater price upside from the hard assets rotation for precious metals and copper than for oil and natural gas for three reasons.
- **#1. Market size.** Investor diversification flows can boost prices more in metals markets, which are (very) small.
- **#2. Supply response.** Higher energy prices incentivize shale supply, which in turn dampens the price boost from investment flows. In contrast, supply is particularly constrained and largely long-cycle for copper and especially precious metals.
- **#3. Storage.** Higher supply and lower demand result in inventory accumulation until hitting storage capacity limits (which are lower for energy than for metals) which can trigger large roll costs for energy futures. In contrast, roll costs remain limited on futures for easy-to-store metals, and don't exist when owning physically backed assets such as precious ETFs.
- **Gold.** We see upside risk to our \$5,400 Dec26 forecast from private sector diversification. We estimate that every 1bp increase in the gold share of US financial portfolios—driven by incremental purchases—raises prices by 1.5%.
- **Copper.** We estimate a boost to prices from a 1 standard deviation (10pp) increase in net managed money as % of open interest of 6.9% in the short-run, which moderates to 4.2% after 1 year as scrap supply rises and demand softens. We estimate upside risks to our forecast from the hard assets rotation and from strategic stockpiling.
- **Oil.** We estimate a boost to prices from a 1 standard deviation (2.7pp) increase in net managed money as % of open interest of 10% in the short-run, which moderates to 7½% after 1 year. We estimate upside risks to our forecast from the hard assets rotation and from geopolitical supply losses.
- **High for longer.** Our analysis suggests that the investor rotation in hard assets

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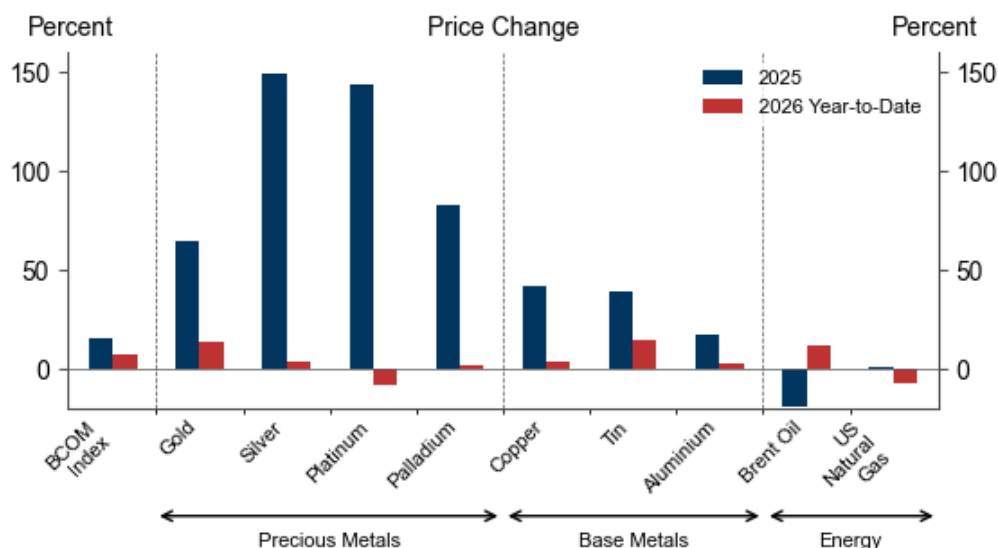
can keep several metals prices high for longer, including above what physical fundamentals justify, which we think is the case right now for copper.

The Boost From the Hard Assets Rotation

Following a 2025 metals rally, many commodities are off to a strong and volatile start in 2026 ([Exhibit 1](#)). Client conversations suggest that investor appetite to diversify into hard assets amidst macro and geopolitical uncertainty (sometimes associated with the debasement theme) is a key driver of the rally.¹

Hard assets are tangible, physical items that have intrinsic value, including commodities, real estate, infrastructure and equipment, and tend to hold value over time, especially during inflation or economic uncertainty.² Given the rotation from soft assets (e.g. fixed income or capital-light equities) to hard assets, we analyze the link between active investor positioning and prices, which is close for commodities such as oil ([Exhibit 2](#)). Specifically, how would a sustained rise in active investor positioning into commodities affect prices? And what are the risks from this rotation to the prices of gold, copper, and oil?

Exhibit 1: Following a Metals Rally in 2025, Most Commodities Are Off to a Strong Start in 2026

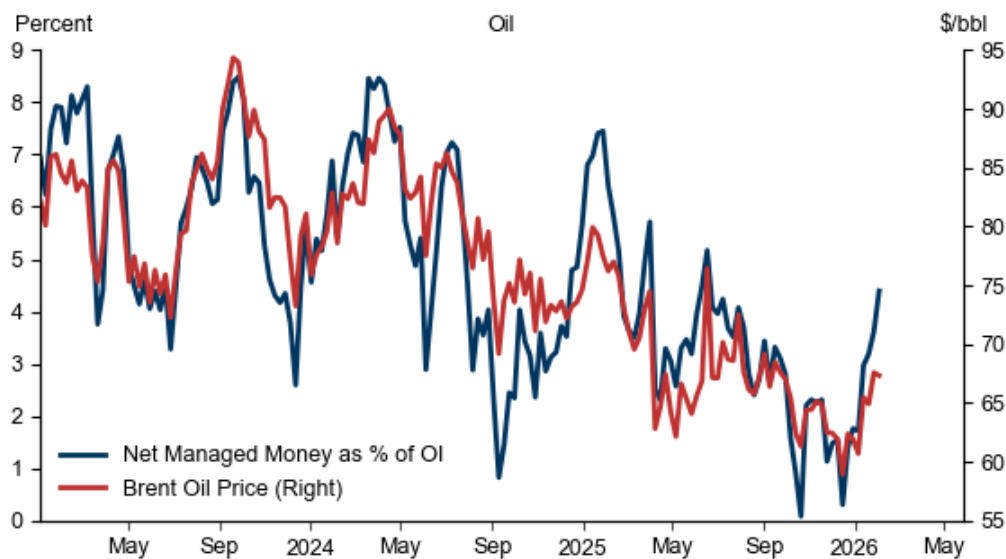


“2026 Year-to-Date” data points incorporate the latest reported price. For all commodities, the latest reported price is Feb 6; for BCOM Index only, the latest reported price is Feb 5.

Source: Bloomberg, LBMA, ICE, NYMEX, LME, LPPM, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

¹ Other drivers of the rise in energy prices include the return of a geopolitical risk premium and the cold US winter.

² The intrinsic value or payoff from holding commodities is the marginal value of benefits that inventories provide (e.g. smooth production, avoiding stockouts) net of storage and insurance costs, i.e. the marginal convenience yield. The commodity spot price is the sum of current and discounted expected future payoffs.

Exhibit 2: A Close Link Between Prices and Active Investor Positioning for Oil

Weekly Tuesday data is plotted. Net managed money and total open interest are the sums across NYMEX WTI, ICE WTI, NYMEX Brent, and ICE Brent, and they include options and futures.

Source: ICE, CFTC, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Potentially Large Price Boosts for Small Commodity Markets

Investors Role in Commodity Markets

There are two types of investors in commodity futures markets: “speculators” or “active” investors, including hedge funds, CTAs and swap dealers, and “index” or “passive” investors, comprised of pension funds, endowments and other real money investors. Our statistical analysis focuses on the price impact of active investors because index investors tend to have little, if any, impact on prices.³ That said, investor conversations suggest that certain passive investors (e.g. pensions funds) are increasingly considering rotating to hard assets, including commodities.

To understand investors’ impact on prices of commodities—physical assets that deliver intrinsic value when consumed—consider the following linkages between physical (or spot) markets and futures markets:

- **Convergence:** as futures approach expiration, their price converges to the spot physical price.
- **Price discovery:** futures prices reflect market expectations of future supply and demand (with a risk premium).
- **Hedging:** futures markets allow producers/consumers in the physical market to manage selling/purchasing price risk.
- **Arbitrage:** When the price difference between the physical and futures markets becomes too large, arbitrageurs step in.

Commodity Markets Are Small

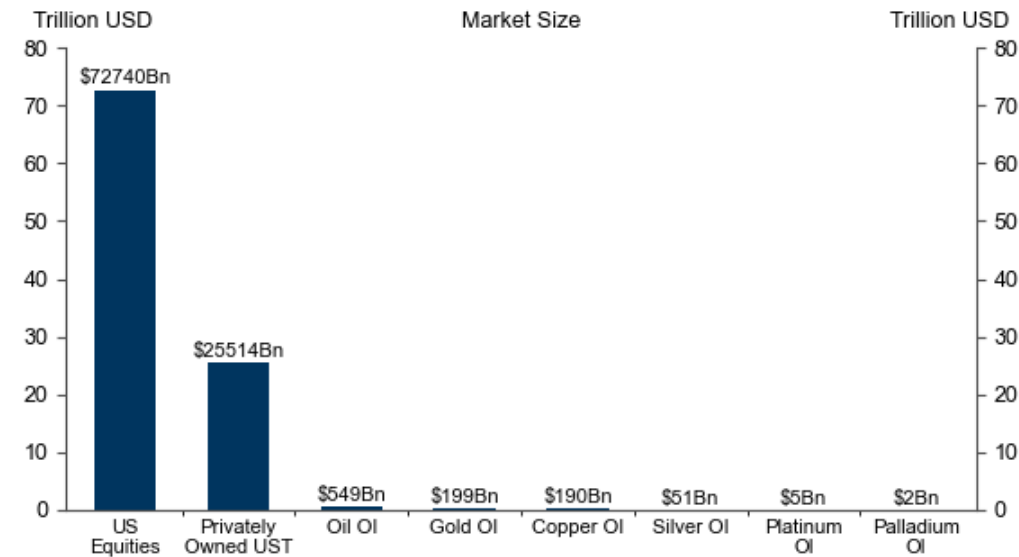
Diversification flows of investors can drive very large short-run commodity price increases because commodity markets are small versus investor portfolios, dominated by the large equity and bond markets. Open interest in the global copper market is ~135 times smaller than the amount of outstanding privately owned US Treasuries (Exhibit 3).⁴

If investors buy futures believing that commodity markets will tighten significantly in the future or provide significant hedging value against tail risks, futures prices can rise above fundamentals. While futures selling by commodity producers can dampen the price boost from investor buying, the net short-run price boost can still be very large if inflows from investors with deep pockets dwarf corporate hedging flows (as has happened since 2025 in the platinum and palladium rallies (Exhibit 1)).

³ Index investors have little, if any, impact on prices because index investors pursue commodity allocations for strategic diversification, and are effectively paid to take risk off the balance sheet of commodity producers, who derive little benefit from holding price risk. Accordingly, index investors provide little fundamental information to the market that would impact physical markets and, in turn, prices. Conversely, speculators bring fundamental views and information to the market, impacting physical supply management and facilitating price discovery. As a result, as speculators buy, prices generally tend to rise, and can exacerbate the volatility that is nonetheless often rooted in fundamental imbalances.

⁴ Relatedly, the natural resources sector accounts for only ~5% of the S&P500 and ~1% of US GDP.

Exhibit 3: Commodities Markets Are Small Compared to Bond and Equity Markets



OI stands for open interest. Oil OI is the sum of Brent and WTI across ICE and NYMEX. Gold and silver OI is from COMEX. Copper OI is the sum of SHFE, LME, and COMEX. Platinum and palladium OI is from NYMEX. Physically backed ETFs play a large role in precious markets.

Source: Bloomberg, US Treasury, LBMA, CFTC, Refinitiv Eikon, ICE, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

The Hard Assets Rotation Implies Greater Upside For Metals

Energy and agriculture historically tend to perform well when large unexpected inflation shocks hit for two reasons. First, energy/food supply disruptions often cause inflation spikes. Second, demand for energy and food (key necessities) tends to remain robust even when inflation-adjusted incomes drop.

However, precious metals and copper have already benefited more and could see greater price upside than oil and natural gas from a hard assets rotation, driven by market concerns about future macro policy, geopolitical or inflation shocks for three reasons.

Factor 1: Market Size

A given volume of investor diversification flows can boost prices more in metals markets, which tend to be small or very small in the case of the ex-gold precious markets such as silver, platinum, and palladium, which have rallied sharply since 2025 ([Exhibit 1](#)).

Factor 2: Supply Response

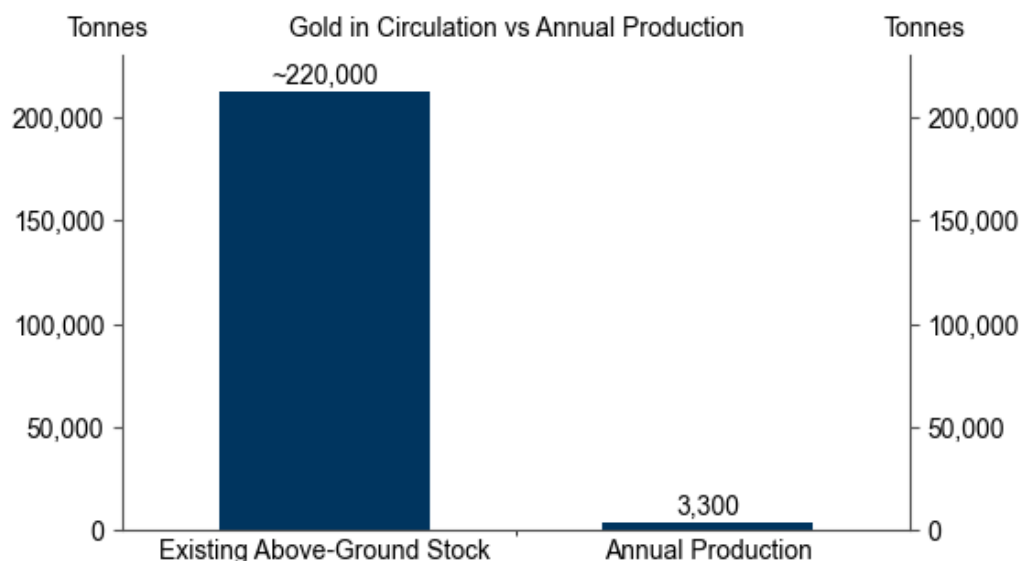
Higher energy prices incentivize short-cycle shale supply, which in turn dampens the price boost from investment flows. In contrast, supply is particularly constrained and largely long-cycle for copper and especially precious metals.

Gold supply doesn't feature in our [demand-driven framework](#) explaining gold prices. The reason is that the above-ground stock edges up at a very modest and stable pace because this stock dwarfs annual mine production, which is stable, and largely unresponsive to price ([Exhibit 4](#)).

Copper mine supply is constrained and long-cycle as it typically takes ~17 years from discovering a copper mine to first production.⁵

⁵ Copper mine supply is constrained and long-cycle because new projects take many years to develop, ore grades are declining, and a large share of previously identified projects remain long-stalled. As a result, higher prices are required to prolong mine lives, incentivise lower-grade extraction, and bring new supply online. This contrasts with aluminium, where supply is less constrained by resources and more by power availability.

Exhibit 4: Nearly All Gold Ever Mined Still Exists, And This Above-Ground Stock Dwarfs Annual Mine Production



End-2024 data.

Source: USGS, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Factor 3: Storage, Futures, and Physically Backed Instruments

When financial flows push prices above fundamentals, higher supply and lower demand can result in inventory accumulation until hitting storage capacity limits.

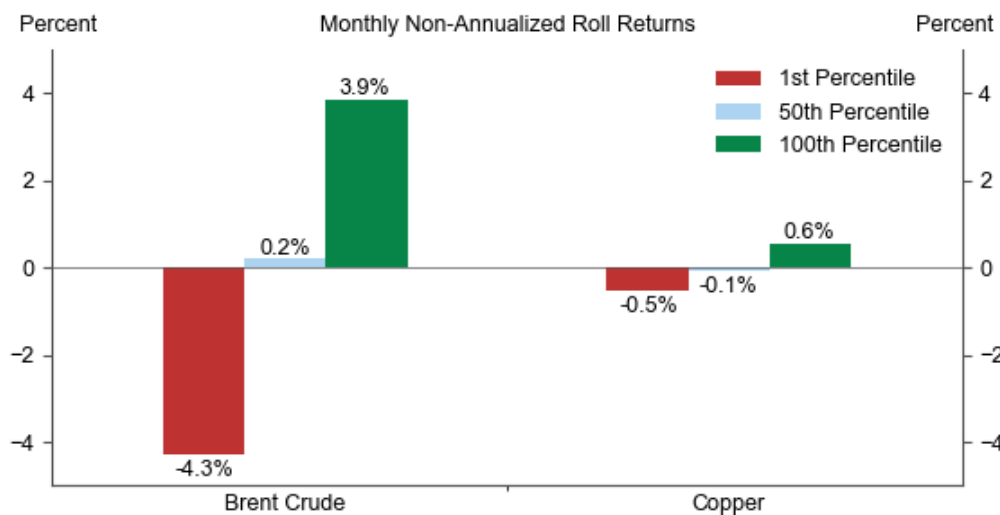
Storage Limits and Futures Roll Costs.

Storage capacity limits are typically lower for energy (and agriculture) than for easy-to-store metals.⁶ Hitting storage constraints (“tank tops”) can substantially reduce roll returns⁷ on energy futures and trigger price corrections, as happened in oil markets in 2020.

In contrast, roll costs tend to remain limited on futures for easy-to-store metals such as copper ([Exhibit 5](#)), and don’t exist when owning physically backed assets such as precious ETFs.

⁶ Commodities that are harder to store (e.g. power, natural gas) also have more volatile prices.

⁷ The roll return on commodities futures—the difference between the spot price and the futures price—is the return that comes from rolling from a futures contract that is about to expire to one with a later expiration.

Exhibit 5: Downside to Roll Returns Is Limited For Easy-to-Store Metals Such as Copper

The sample is from January 2007 through January 2026.

The roll return corresponds to ("static") roll returns in the front of futures curves and is estimated using end-of-month values for the GSCI Brent crude and GSCI copper excess and spot return indices.

Source: S&P, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Dynamic curve strategies dampen futures' roll cost when inventories are near storage limits (i.e. when the front of the curve is upward sloping/in contango) by going out on the flatter part of the curve to roll. That said, these strategies incentivize production by raising long-dated futures prices. But because supply tends to be long-cycle for mined metals, the near-term negative impact on spot prices from higher supply/inventories is more limited for long-cycle metals than for shale energy. This, again, implies that investor flows can boost prices more for metals.

Physically Backed Instruments.

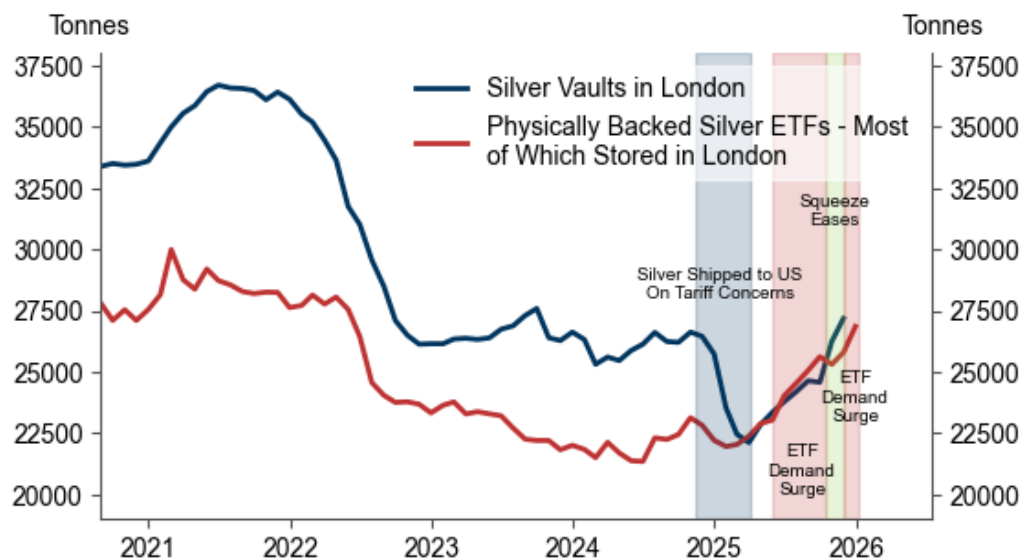
Roll costs don't exist when investors don't own futures but instead own physically backed assets such as ETFs, a key vehicle for exposure to gold and silver in US private sector portfolios.

In addition to not facing potentially very negative roll costs, the prominence of physically backed instruments such as ETFs (or tokenized gold) can also amplify the price boost from investor inflows by reducing available inventory not backing up ETFs in pricing centers to very low levels. This is precisely what has happened to silver since last year.⁸

Speculation around US trade policy—with silver theoretically eligible for tariffs of up to 50%—prompted pre-positioning of metal into the US in 2025, drawing inventory out of London and reducing the available float. Thinner inventories have created conditions for squeezes, where rallies accelerate as ETF investor flows absorb remaining metal in the London vaults and reverse sharply when tightness eases.

⁸ The major gold/silver ETFs are physically backed because the ETFs tend to hold physical bars stored in vaults (often London). While commodity futures are technically backed by physical holdings (as they can be settled by delivering the commodity), the vast majority of say oil futures never reach delivery. And open interest often exceeds immediately available storage.

Exhibit 6: The Rise in Silver ETF Demand Has Reduced Available Inventory in London, Contributing to High and Volatile Prices



We track physically backed silver ETFs under Bloomberg ticker `\\\"ETSIOTL\\\"`. Most of the silver backing these ETFs is stored in London vaults, the global hub for silver trading. For reference, around 80% of the silver held by SLV — the largest ETF — is stored in London, with the remainder in New York. While a direct measure of London's available float is not published, it can be approximated by subtracting physically backed ETF holdings from total silver stored in London vaults, as ETFs account for the bulk of allocated silver in the London market.

We next estimate the risks from the rotation in hard assets to our price forecasts for gold, copper, and oil.

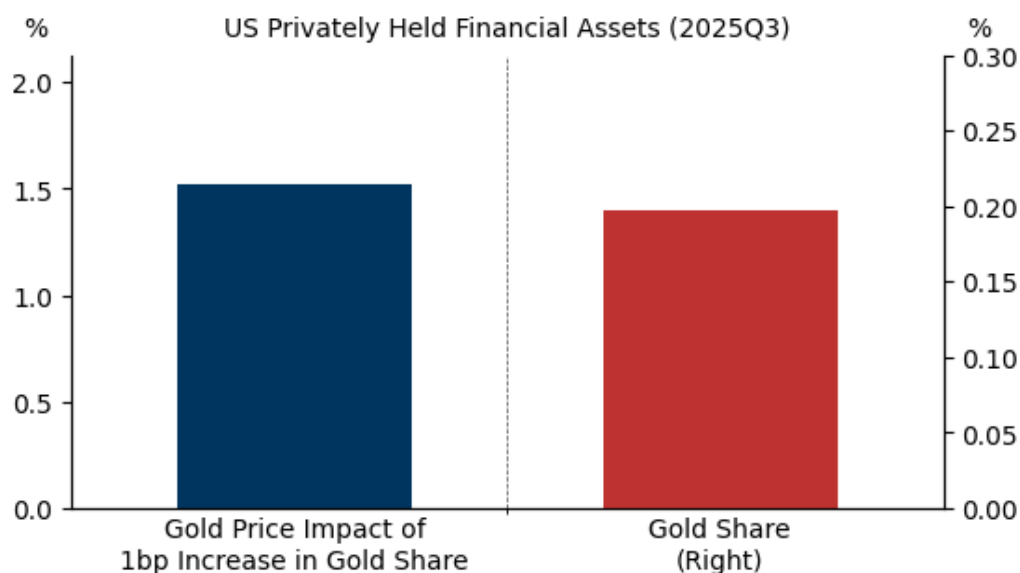
Gold: The Hardest Commodity

Gold's limited, slow-moving, price-inelastic supply is what has given gold its status as a neutral store of value and is also why gold is likely the cleanest commodity expression of the rotation in hard assets/private sector diversification theme.

Private sector diversification is also the key upside risk to our \$5,400 Dec26 forecast, which only assumes i) that central banks continue to buy at their elevated pace of the past 12 months and ii) a modest boost to ETF holdings from 50bp of Fed cuts.

With gold ETF allocations in US private sector financial portfolios at only ~0.2%, there is room for additional diversification into gold. We estimate that every 1bp increase in the gold share of US financial portfolios—driven by incremental gold purchases—raises prices by 1.5%. (This diversification is increasingly expressed via call options, which has also boosted price volatility).

Exhibit 7: We Estimate that Each 1bp Increase in Gold's Share of US Financial Portfolios—Driven by Incremental Investor Buying—Lifts the Gold Price by About 1.5%.



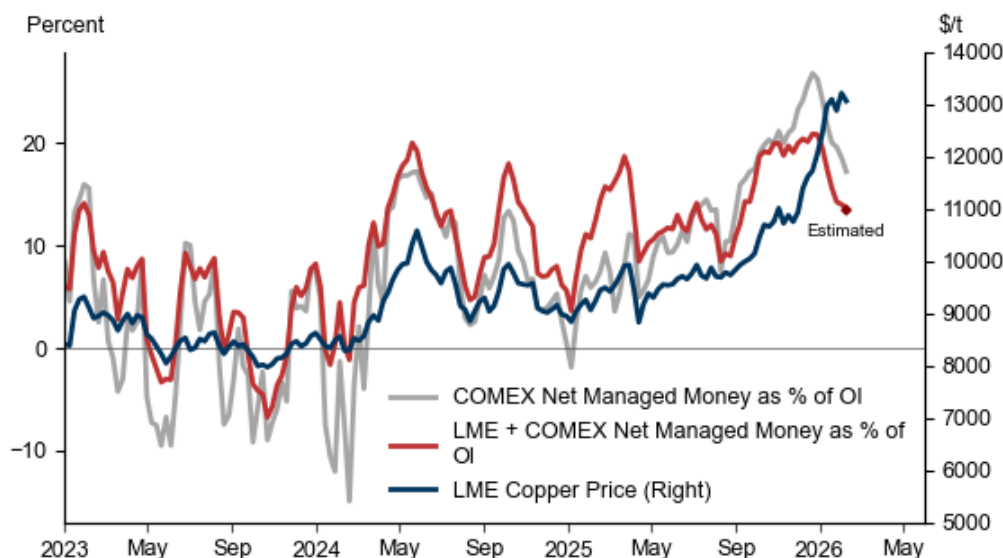
We calculate the gold ETF share in privately held financial portfolios as: $\text{gold ETF share} = \text{US gold ETF market cap} \div \text{US financial portfolios}$, where financial portfolios are defined as privately held debt securities and corporate equities based on US Flow of Funds data. We include all sectors excluding federal government, state & local government, monetary authority, US depository institutions, foreign banking offices, and rest of world.

Source: Federal Reserve Board, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Copper: Upside Risk From Positioning and the Commodity Control Cycle

Copper has already benefited and may benefit further from the hard assets rotation as it combines constrained supply, an attractive long-run demand outlook, and ease of storage. That said, measures of active investor positioning have recently moderated even if prices stay elevated ([Exhibit 8](#)).

Exhibit 8: The Copper Price Has Remained High This Year Despite a Moderation in Active Investor Positioning



Net Managed Money (combining options and futures) as % of OI combines CFTC Managed Money net positioning in COMEX copper and LME Investment Funds net positioning in LME copper, divided by total open interest across COMEX and LME. Diamond denotes latest estimated net managed money, combining current COMEX data (as of Tuesday 3 Feb 2026) with LME positioning held at the prior week level (as of Friday, 30 Jan 2026) due to reporting lags.

Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

While we are long-term bullish copper (with a \$15,000/t forecast for 2035), our near-term base case remains that the LME copper price moderates from \$12,994/t to \$11,200/t by 2026Q4 because prices have overshoot our estimate of fair value. This fair value estimate is based on ex-US inventories (because LME prices are set in London), which declined in 2024 (as anticipation of potential US tariffs pulled copper in the US) but have recently built, as China copper demand has softened.

We next estimate the upside risks to our 2026Q4 copper forecast from a potential rise in positioning on the hard assets rotation in 3 steps.

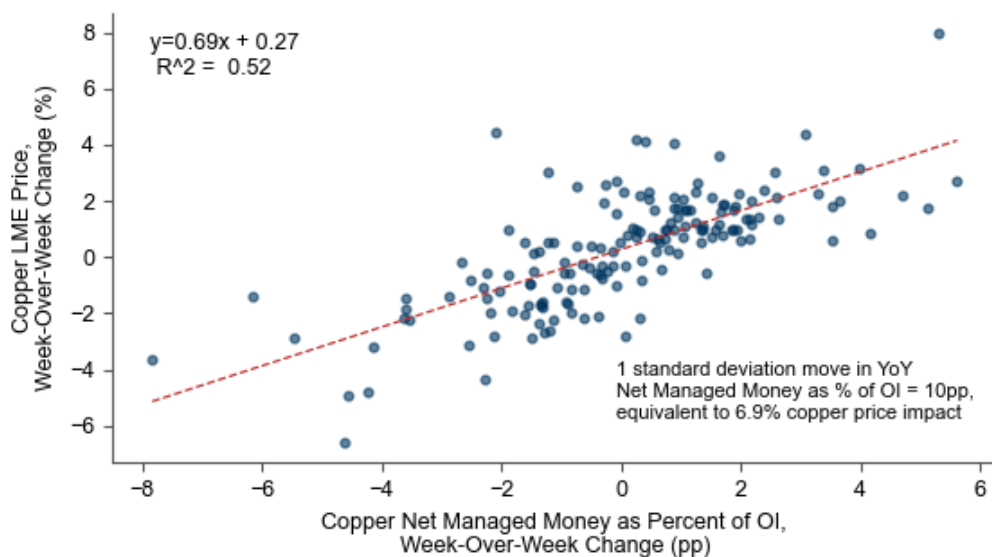
First, we estimate a short-term boost to copper prices from a 1pp increase (0.1 standard deviation) in net managed money as % of open interest of 0.7% ([Exhibit 9](#)). This is equivalent to a 6.9% short-term copper price boost from a 1 standard deviation year-over-year change in positioning. To be clear, this short-term relationship is not entirely causal as active investors typically increase net length when the outlook for physical balances (or the skew of risks around it) is tightening.⁹

Second, we estimate that this boost from a 1pp increase in net managed money as % of

⁹ Moreover, the short-term relationship is unlikely to hold over the long-run because supply and demand respond and because prices may be higher when a significant reallocation occurs then after the reallocation has been absorbed.

open interest moderates from 0.7% to 0.4% after 1 year as scrap supply rises and demand softens on substitution in response to higher prices ([Exhibit 10](#)). The appendix illustrates the significant response of copper scrap supply and of China copper demand to prices ([Exhibit 15](#), [Exhibit 16](#)).¹⁰

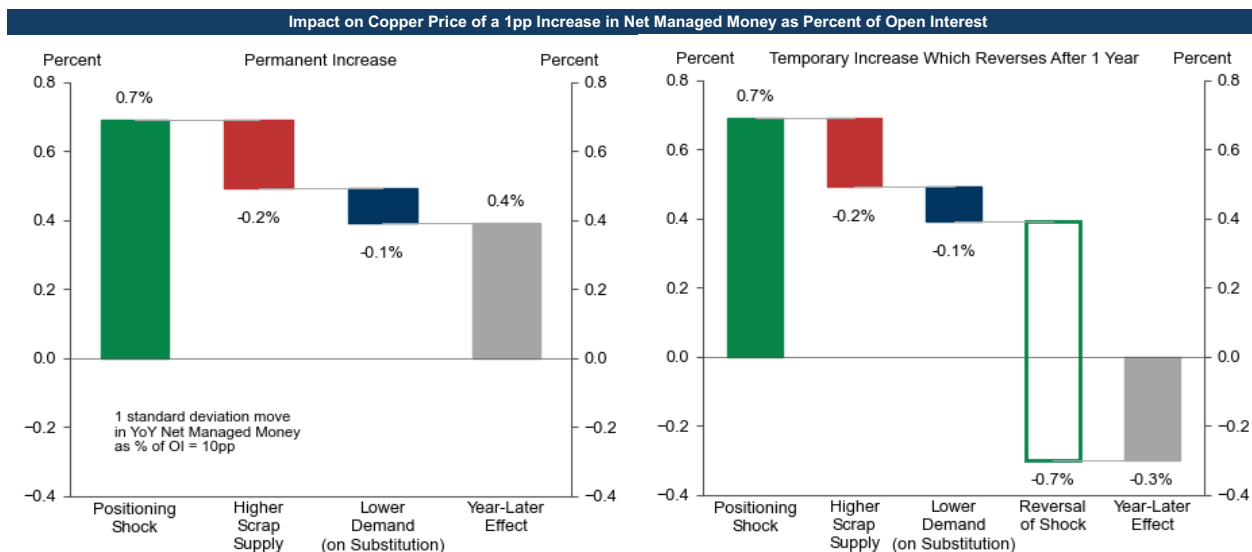
Exhibit 9: We Estimate a Short-Term Boost to Copper Prices From a 1pp Increase in Net Managed Money as % of Open Interest of 0.7%



Net managed money is combined for COMEX and LME.

Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 10: We Estimate a Boost to Prices From a 1pp Increase (0.1 Standard Deviation) in Net Managed Money as % of Open Interest of 0.7% in the Short-Run, Which Moderates to 0.4% After 1 Year as Scrap Supply Rises and Demand Softens



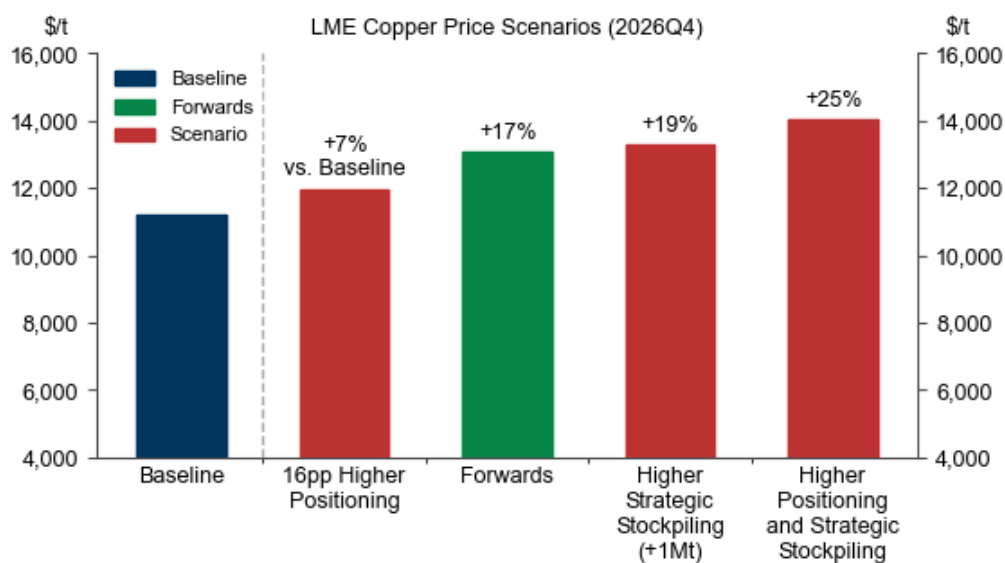
Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Third, we apply our rule of thumb for the year-later price impact of positioning increases in 3 risk scenarios ([Exhibit 11](#)):

¹⁰ The hit from higher prices to copper demand reflects temporary destocking (as buyers postpone purchases for ~3-6 months) and persistent substitution.

- **Higher positioning:** Assuming a substantial 16pp rise in LME+COMEX net managed money as % of OI vs. our baseline, we estimate 7% of upside to our 2026Q4 copper price base case.¹¹ (This scenario assumes the same physical factors weighing on prices as our base case).
- **Higher strategic stockpiling:** Assuming 1 million tonnes higher global strategic stockpiling in 2026 (as countries secure supply in the commodity control cycle), we estimate 19% of upside to our 2026Q4 copper price base case¹².
- **Higher positioning and strategic stockpiling:** Assuming 16pp higher positioning in LME+COMEX net managed money as % of OI and 1 million tonnes higher global strategic stockpiling in 2026, we estimate 25% of upside to our 2026Q4 copper price base case.

Exhibit 11: We See Upside to Our Copper Price Forecast From the Hard Assets Rotation Lifting Positioning and From Strategic Stockpiling



Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

¹¹ For reference, LME+COMEX net managed money as % of now stands at ~14% and the historical maximum stands at 21% in late December 2025.

¹² The 1 million tonnes strategic stockpiling scenario reflects potential discretionary purchases by China and the US (including DoD-related demand) amid heightened supply-security concerns, equivalent to increasing strategic inventory coverage to around 60 days each. The US has announced Project Vault, a government initiative to establish a Strategic Critical Minerals Reserve, and 60 days of US copper demand coverage corresponds to around ~250kt. Using our rule of thumb linking copper balances (in days of demand) to prices, a 1 million tonnes increase in strategic stockpiling, equivalent to 13 days of tightening in the balance, implies 19% upside to prices, based on an estimated ~1.4% price impact per balance day.

Oil: Upside Risk From Positioning and Geopolitics

While we see metals as a cleaner expression of the hard assets theme than energy, our investor conversations suggest that the hard assets rotation has contributed to the year-to-date rise in active investor oil positioning from low levels along with related geopolitical uncertainty.

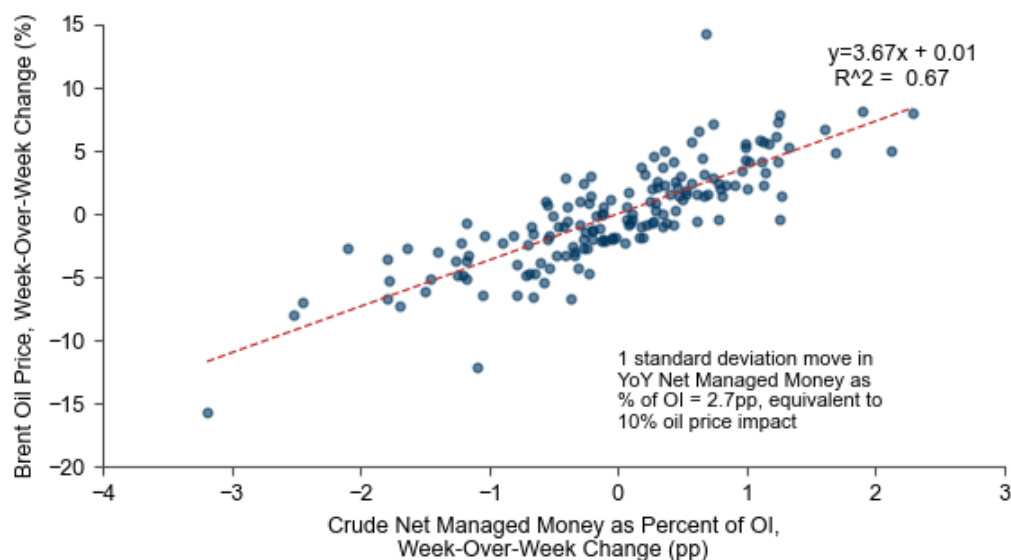
While our long-run crude oil price forecast is above the forwards (Brent 2030 forecast of \$75), our near-term base case remains that Brent moderates from \$68/bbl to a bottom of \$54 by 2026Q4 for two reasons. First, we expect a 2026 surplus of just over 2mb/d assuming the January supply disruptions in Kazakhstan and the US ease and no large new supply disruptions (if US policymakers focus on affordability). Second, we assume that the share of global inventory increases in the OECD commercial pricing centers picks up from its unusually low just under 10% share in 2025 to the historical norm of ~30% (as the pace of accumulation of sanctioned barrels on water moderates).

We next estimate upside risks to our oil price forecast, including from a potential rise in positioning, in 3 steps.

First, we estimate a short-term boost to oil prices from a 1pp increase in net managed money as % of open interest of 3.7% ([Exhibit 12](#)). This is equivalent to a 10% short-term oil price boost from a 1 standard deviation year-over-year change in positioning.

Second, we estimate that this oil price boost from a 1pp increase in net managed money as % of open interest moderates from 3.7% to 2.8% after 1 year as short-cycle shale supply rises and demand softens in response to higher prices ([Exhibit 10](#), left panel).

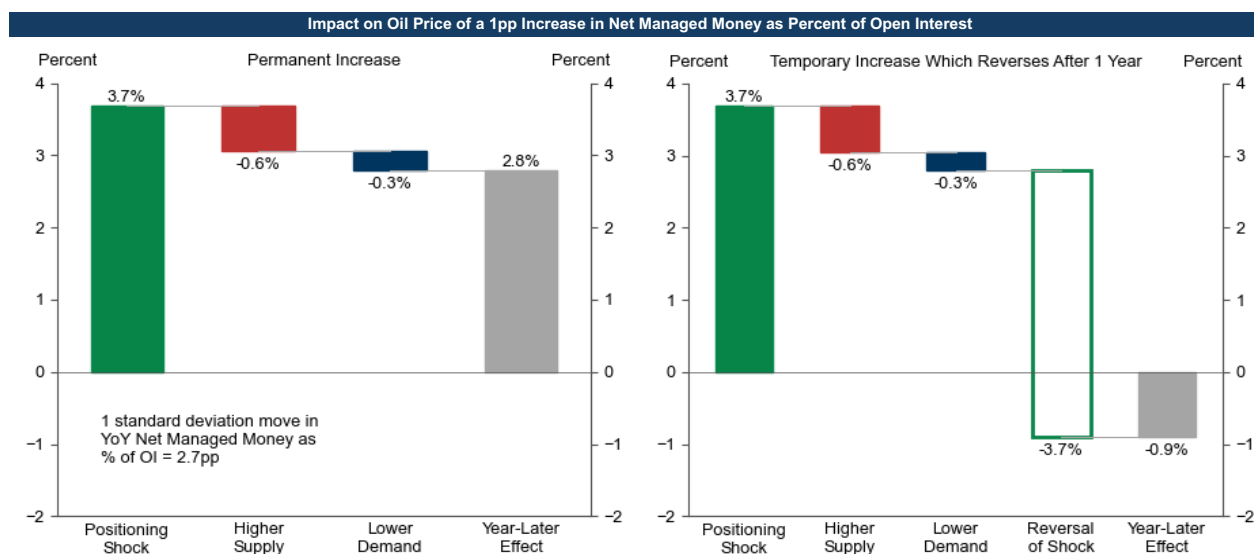
Exhibit 12: We Estimate That a 1pp Increase in Net Managed Money As % of Open Interest Raises Oil Prices by Nearly 4% in the Short-Run



The sample is comprised of Tuesday data points from the beginning of January 2023 through the latest week.

Source: ICE, CFTC, Refinitiv Eikon, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 13: We Estimate a Boost to Prices From a 1pp (0.4 Standard Deviation) Increase in Net Managed Money as % of Open Interest of 3.7% in the Short-Run, Which Moderates to 2.8% After 1 Year As the Supply-Demand Balance Softens

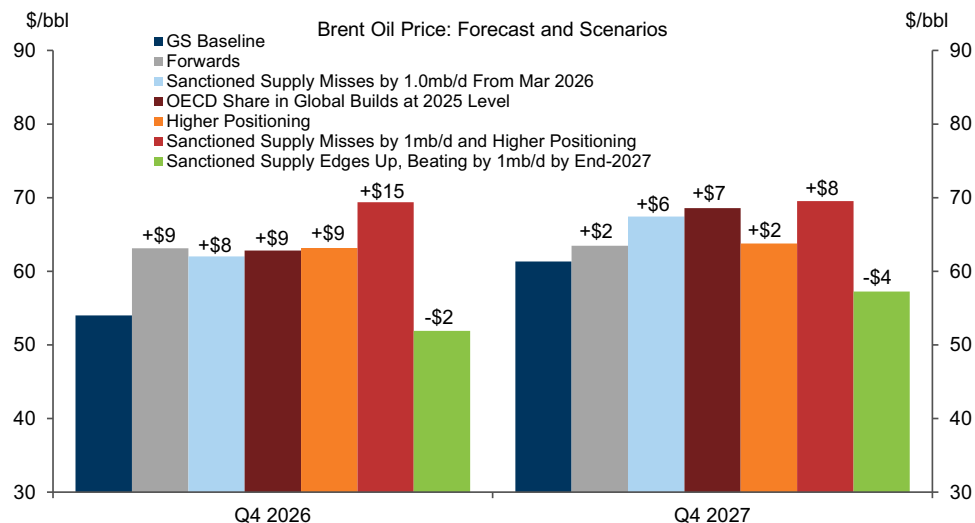


Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Third, we apply our estimate of the short-run price impact of positioning increases and our pricing framework in 2 positioning scenarios:

- **Higher positioning:** Assuming a gradual 4pp rise in net managed money as % of OI over 4 quarters vs. our baseline, we estimate \$9 of upside to our 2026Q4 oil price base case. (This scenario assumes the same inventory builds weighing on prices as our base case).
- **Higher positioning and supply disruption:** Assuming a gradual 4pp rise in net managed money as % of OI over 4 quarters vs. our baseline and a 1mb/d sustained miss in sanctioned supply from March 2026 (e.g. Iran or Russia supply disruption), we estimate \$15 of upside to our 2026Q4 oil price base case.

We also consider three other scenarios while keeping positioning from our baseline. The two extra upside scenarios assume i) a 1mb/d miss in sanctioned supply (\$8 of upside to our 2026Q4 base case) or ii) an equally low 7% OECD landed share in global inventory builds as in 2025 (\$9 upside). The final downside scenario assumes a beat in sanctioned supply, which rises to 1.0mb/d by end-2027, for instance under a Russia-Ukraine peace deal (\$2 downside).

Exhibit 14: Upside Risk to Our Oil Price Forecast From Positioning and Geopolitics

The “Higher Positioning” scenario assumes a boost to positioning above our baseline equivalent to the 95th percentile of year-over-year changes in net managed money as % of open interest using a quarterly dataset starting in 2011Q2. The numerical labels indicate differences relative to the GS Baseline forecast for each period.

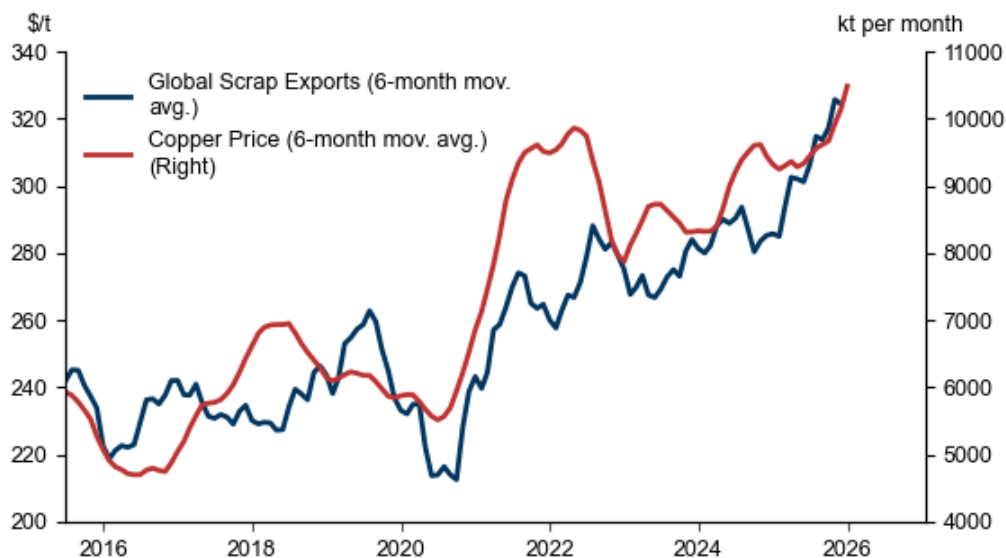
Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Higher For Longer

Our analysis suggests that the investor rotation in hard assets can keep several metals prices high for longer, including above what physical fundamentals justify, which we think is the case right now for copper.

Appendix: Copper's Price Sensitivity

Exhibit 15: Global Copper Scrap Exports Are Price Sensitive



Global copper scrap exports are until Nov25 and LME price until Dec25

Source: Bloomberg, GTT, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 16: China Copper Demand is Price Sensitive

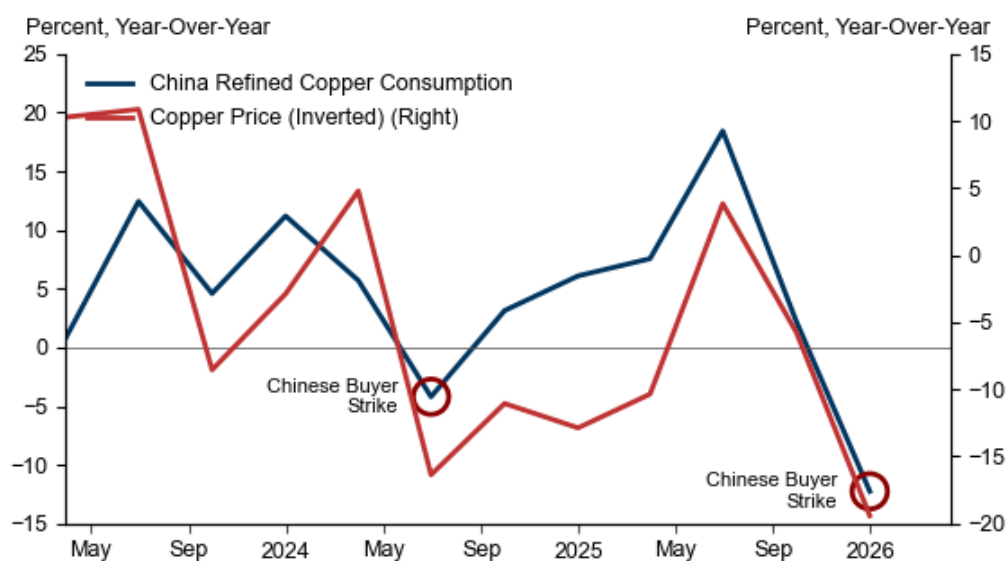
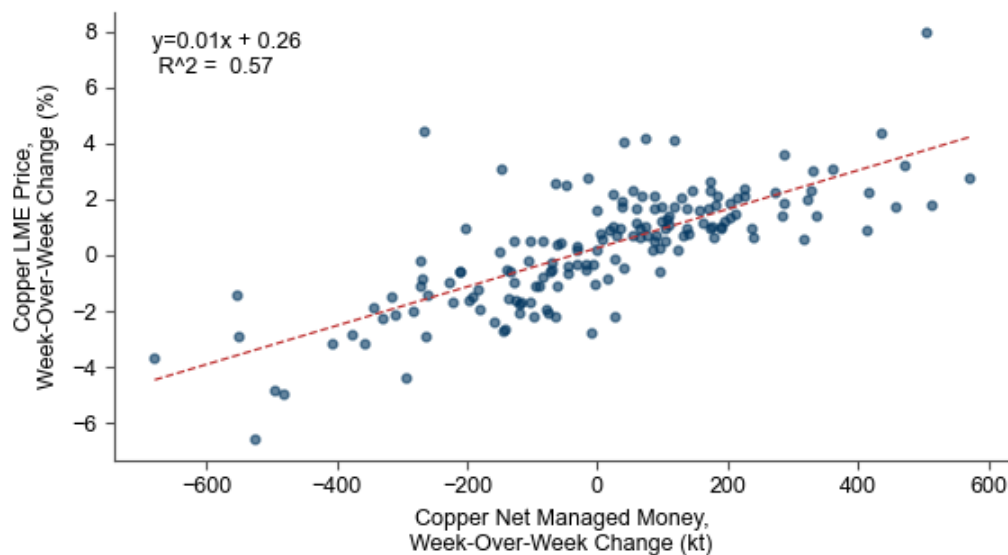


Exhibit shows China apparent refined copper consumption, estimated as: domestic refined production + imports – exports + change in inventories (monthly).

Source: SMM, CRU, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

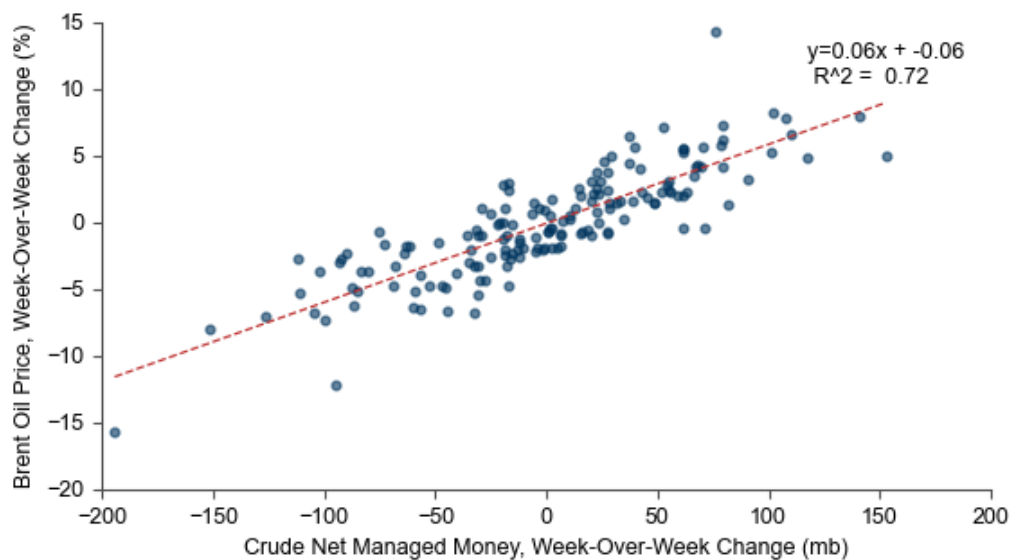
Appendix: Short-Run Effect of Positioning on Prices

Exhibit 17: We Estimate That a 100kt Increase in Net Managed Money Raises Copper Prices by Nearly 1% in the Short-Run



Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 18: We Estimate That a 100mb Increase in Net Managed Money Raises Oil Prices by Nearly 6% in the Short-Run



Source: ICE, CFTC, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Disclosure Appendix

Reg AC

We, Daan Struyven, Alexandra Paulus, Lavinia Forcellese, Lina Thomas, Yulia Zhestkova Grigsby and Samantha Dart, hereby certify that all of the views expressed in this report accurately reflect our personal views, which have not been influenced by considerations of the firm's business or client relationships.

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